



Rosette Nebula and NGC 2244

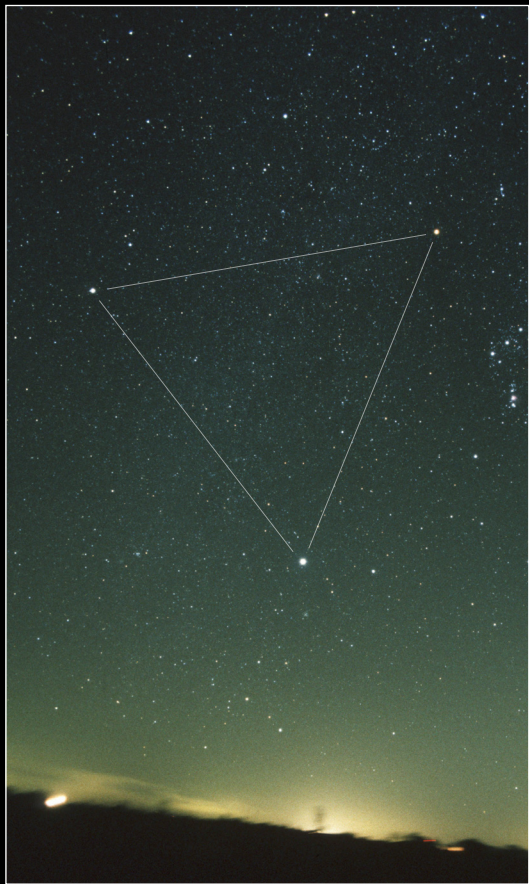
This spectacular telescope view of the Rosette Nebula in the constellation of Monoceros, the unicorn, reveals an open cluster of stars, NGC 2244, in the heart of the nebula. The surrounding nebula shows up well in photographs but not to the eye.

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

The path of the Milky Way extends across the sky, stretching from the southeastern horizon to the northwest. Along its path, starting closest to the southern horizon, are the constellations Centaurus, Crux, Carina, Vela, and Puppis, and then Canis Major, which is overhead. Its bright star, Sirius, and brilliant Canopus of Carina, are the two brightest stars of all. They are seen high in the sky through out this month.

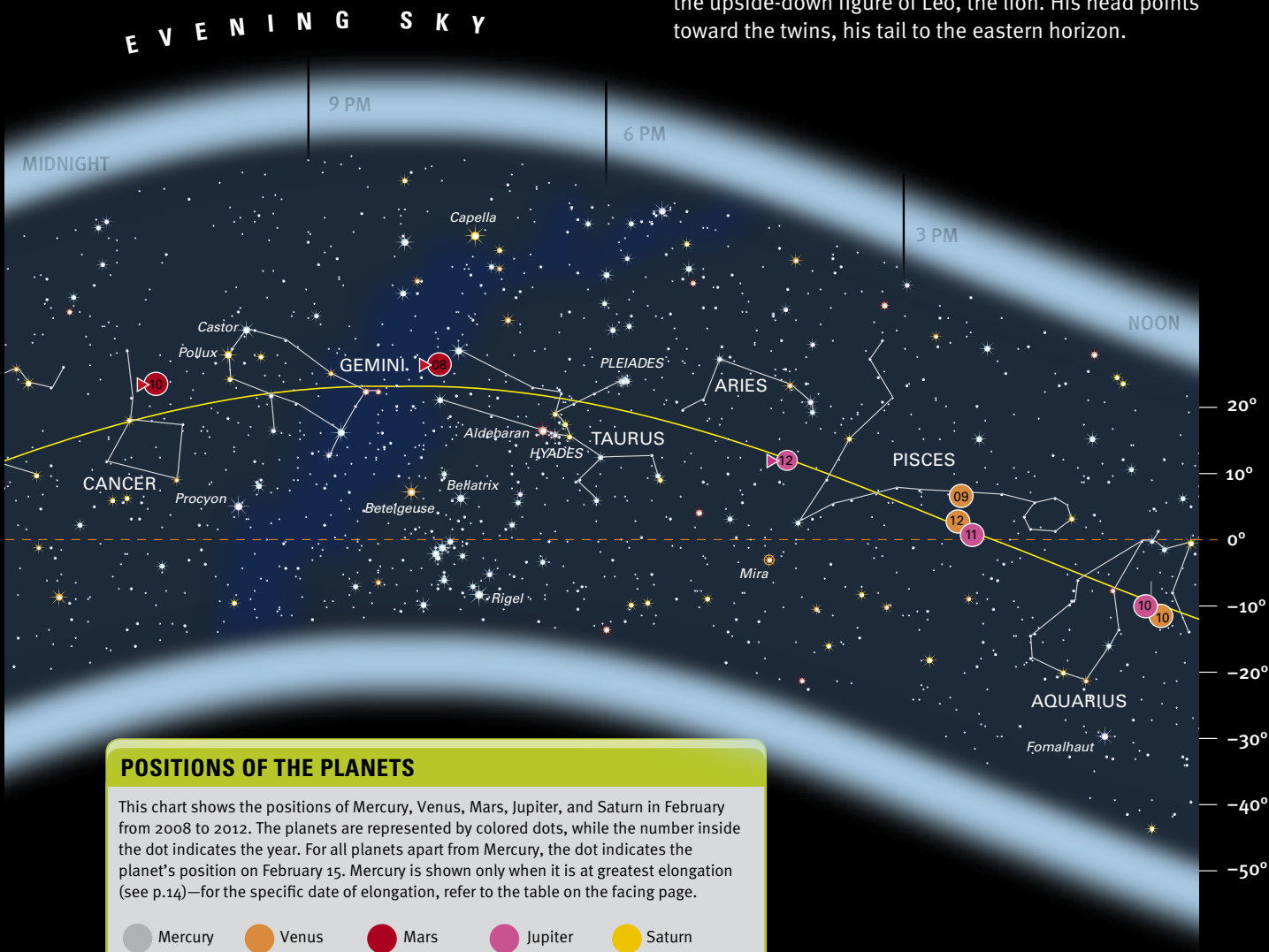
The equilateral triangle known to northern-hemisphere observers as the Winter Triangle is made by linking orange-red Betelgeuse and the white stars Sirius and Procyon. It is seen high above the northwestern horizon. Sirius is the highest star; below it are Betelgeuse and Procyon, to the left and right, respectively. Within the triangle is the constellation Monoceros, the unicorn, which also lies in the path of the Milky Way. Close to its border with Orion is the open star cluster NGC 2244, which is visible through binoculars.

The stars Castor and Pollux, which mark the heads of the Gemini twins, are seen by looking north. At magnitude 1.2, Pollux is the brighter of the two, but Castor (magnitude 1.6) is possibly the more interesting. A small telescope will show it as a pair of stars. At right, to the east, is Cancer, the crab, and the upside-down figure of Leo, the lion. His head points toward the twins, his tail to the eastern horizon.



The Winter Triangle

Despite urban light pollution from the horizon, the Winter Triangle is visible here. Brilliant Sirius in Canis Major is just below the center of the image. Above and to the left is Procyon in Canis Minor. At center right is Orion; its star Betelgeuse forms the third point of the triangle.



EXAMPLES



09 Mars's position on February 15, 2009



09 Saturn's position on February 15, 2009. The arrow indicates that the planet is in retrograde motion (see p.14)